

Arts and Crafts

Spurred by a reaction against industrialization, 19th-century English reformers created a new movement, instigated by designer, artist, writer and manufacturer William Morris (1834–96). Arts and Crafts gathered momentum and spread across Europe and the United States. In the belief that machines and mass-production were lowering the quality of life, proponents revived ancient crafts, collaborating in medieval-style workshops to hand-produce furniture, books, ornaments, tiles and other objects. Although these smaller items were the main concern, architecture had a prominent role. During an apprenticeship with the architect G.E. Street, Morris befriended Philip Webb (1831–1915), who became a leading Arts and Crafts architect and designer. A key tenet was ‘truth to materials’: materials were usually locally sourced, and functions of buildings determined their design and construction, with no excessive ornament. Many Arts and Crafts buildings recalled Tudor or Elizabethan manors, or Gothic styling, such as Webb and Morris’s Red House (opposite, 1859) in Bexleyheath, Kent.

